dotted with early historic settlements and cities—from the Ganga bank opposite ancient Pataliputra, through Vaishali, Katragarh, and Balrajgarh to the terai area. Considering the marshes in the terai, travelling by elephant would have been a sensible option. Alongside, there would have been bullock carts carrying provisions, and an armed contingent. In the terai, during the nineteenth century, the cart tracks on which bullock carts travelled were so circuitous that they took double the direct distance to the destination. It may have been worse in Ashoka's day. Many streams will also have had to be crossed: rivers and rivulets such as the Banganga, Tilar, Jamuar, and Siswa.[21] People in the villages and towns on the route may have been made aware of the king's travel plans. The presence of advance parties would have ensured it while crosschecking the state of repair of roads, vetting the halting places along the way, ensuring provisions of animal fodder. Elaborate arrangements will have been put in place to receive the royal visitor at each point of his halt.

Over the days that Ashoka was in the terai (there is no knowing how long), arrangements would have had to be made in the towns he stayed in. It is possible that he halted briefly at the city of Tilaurakot near the eastern bank of the Banganga and not far from the places that he would visit. Whether this was then called Kapilavastu or was known by another another name we don't know.[22] The fortified site, though, was most impressive. Originally of mud, brick walls, protected by a deep ditch, were subsequently raised.[23] The terai bristled with habitation sites of all kinds and formed an important segment of the imperial domain, quite apart from being important to Buddhists. The local administration will have been on its toes in many of the locations.

Which of these pilgrim places did Ashoka visit? Lumbini first of all, perhaps, being already a hoary place of pilgrimage. What today lies inside the modern Maya Devi temple pre-dated Ashoka by centuries.[24] The Buddha's birthplace is represented as a square brick box-like platform on